



Suriname

Suriname is a former Dutch colony on the north coast of South America. Democracy was restored in 1991, after almost 11 years of military rule. The Netherlands is still the main supplier of aid.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly covered by tropical rainforest. Coastal plain rises to central plateaus and the Guiana Highlands.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot and humid, but cooled by trade winds. High rainfall, especially in the interior.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Dutch brought laborers from South Asia and Java. Independence saw mass emigration: over 300,000 Surinamese live in the Netherlands. Of those left, over 85% live near the coast, the rest in scattered rainforest communities. Indigenous Amerindians only number a few thousand. *Bosnegers* – descended from runaway African slaves – fought the military government in the late 1980s. Under civilian rule, each group has had a political party representing its interests.



THE ECONOMY

Alumina and gold are the key exports. Rice and bananas are main cash crops. Oil production and tourism are growing. Excessive bureaucracy.



INSIGHT: In a 1667 Anglo-Dutch deal, Holland gained Suriname but lost New Amsterdam (now New York)



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Suriname

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: Paramaribo

POPULATION: 519,700

TOTAL AREA: 63,039 sq. miles
(163,270 sq. km)

DENSITY: 8 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Sranan (Creole), Dutch*, Javanese, Sarnami, Hindi, other

RELIGIONS: Christian 48%, Hindu 27%, Muslim 20%, traditional beliefs 5%

ETHNIC MIX: South Asian 27%, other 25%, Creole 18%, Javanese 15%, Black 15%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Surinamese dollar = 100 cents